Rumors Across Borders: Transnational Ties, Social Media, and Latino Support for Trump

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Abstract

Why has Latino support for Trump increased despite his xenophobic and anti-Latino rhetoric? I argue that exposure to political misinformation helps explain this shift. Many Latinos are embedded in transnational information environments sustained by cross-border ties and maintained through frequent social media use. These ties expand the political content Latinos encounter, while social media conditions whether that content is accepted as credible. Belief in misinformation, in turn, is associated with more favorable evaluations of Trump and a greater likelihood of reporting a 2020 Trump vote or intended 2024 Trump support. I test implications of this moderated-mediation theory using an original 2024 YouGov survey with a Latino oversample. The findings show robust associations between transnational ties and exposure to misinformation, and between belief in misinformation and support for Trump. The conditional relationship among ties, social media use, and belief is consistent with the theory but sensitive to model specification. These results suggest that transnational information environments help shape Latino support for Trump. More broadly, the paper underscores the importance of treating exposure and belief as distinct phenomena and of incorporating transnational networks into the study of political communication.

Keywords: *Latino Politics, Misinformation, Transnational Ties, Social Media Use, Information Environments.*

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Why would a significant share of U.S. Latinos support a candidate who has repeatedly made xenophobic and anti-Latino statements, called immigrants from Latin America "people from shithole countries," vowed mass deportation, and built a political identity around anti-immigrant sentiment? Even more, why would this support increase over time? In 2024, 48% of Latinos supported Trump in the presidential election, compared to 32% in 2020, and 28% in 2016 (Fraga, Velez and West, 2025; Pew Research Center, 2018, 2025; Roper Center for Public Opinion Research, 2020). This is particularly puzzling because issues related to immigration matter to Latinos (Branton, 2007; Sanchez, 2006), and a significant number are first, second, or third-generation Americans. Latino support has increased despite the anti-Latino xenophobic remarks and harmful policies implemented by the Trump administration.

Scholars have provided a range of explanations, involving ideological sorting, economic concern, religiosity, and gendered cultural norms. For instance, some scholars argue that Latinos hold conservative cultural and economic values that ultimately align them with the Republican Party, so recent voting behavior can be explained under an ideological sorting lens (Fraga, Velez and West, 2025; Cortina and Rottinghaus, 2022). Yet others argue that Latinos concerned about the state of the economy were more likely to support Trump (Garcia-Rios et al., 2025). Religious affiliation and gendered norms are emphasized by other scholars, as evangelism and more traditional conceptions of masculinity seem to map more closely to the values espoused by the Republican Party (Martinez and Martí, 2024; Geiger and Reny, 2024). Missing from these explanations is an account that considers Latinos' information environment, which often extends beyond U.S. borders and includes information transmitted through cross-border social networks.

Latinos are more likely than white or Black Americans to be embedded in transnational information environments because they maintain dense cross-border social networks, which I call transnational ties. These ties expose Latinos to political narratives circulating beyond U.S. domestic information environments. Social media facilitates the maintenance of these relationships and conditions the information transmitted through them. Recent work shows that Latinos are politically active on social media at rates comparable to those of whites and that Latino online political activity is especially pronounced on certain platforms, such as WhatsApp (Abrajano et al., 2025). I therefore argue that transnational ties shape exposure to political rumors and misinformation,[1] while social media conditions whether that exposure translates into belief. Because much of the misinformation circulating online leans right, this process ultimately increases support for Trump.

The theory consists of three causal steps. First, transnational ties expand the universe of political content to which Latinos are exposed. These ties expose Latinos to narratives perceived as credible because they originate from trusted social contacts with direct experience abroad. Second, the exposure to information from transnational ties does not necessarily translate into belief unless a moderating factor is present. As emphasized in the misinformation literature, exposure and belief are conceptually and empirically distinct (Guess, Nagler and Tucker, 2019; Tucker et al., 2018; Pennycook and Rand, 2021). What matters here are the conditions under which exposure becomes belief. Social media is a key condition because platforms repeatedly surface reinforcing content, provide signals of social endorsement, and facilitate interpersonal sharing across networks (Bakshy, Messing and Adamic, 2015; Avram et al., 2020; Bail, 2021; Abrajano et al., 2025). As a result, more frequent social media use can increase repeated exposure and the perceived credibility of information encountered through transnational ties. Third, misinformation is politically consequential (Allcott and Gentzkow, 2017; Tucker et al., 2018; Hopkins, Sides and Citrin, 2019; Pennycook and Rand, 2021; Berlinski et al., 2023). Given that political misinformation is asymmetrically right-leaning (Allcott and Gentzkow, 2017; Garrett and Bond, 2021; Freelon, Marwick and Kreiss, 2020),

[1] Although the title refers to "rumors," the paper uses the more precise analytical term misinformation throughout. The two concepts are related but distinct. Rumors are unverified claims whose truth value may be uncertain at the time they circulate, whereas misinformation refers to false or misleading information regardless of intent. Because the survey measures belief in demonstrably false political claims, misinformation is the appropriate term for the empirical analyses. The title uses "rumors" as a broader descriptor of the cross-border circulation of politically consequential claims through interpersonal networks, while the analyses focus specifically on misinformation.

belief in misinformation pulls many Latinos toward Trump.

I test this argument using the Latino sample from an original survey fielded by YouGov in September 2024. The total number of respondents is 1,500. The survey also includes a nationally matched comparison sample, which I use descriptively to show that Latinos are more likely than white and Black Americans to report transnational ties and frequent cross-border contact. Both the general sample and the Latino oversample were matched to the sampling frames by gender, age, and education. The general sample was also matched on race. The sampling frames are politically representative and are modeled on the US adult population.[2] The instrument was administered in Spanish and English and includes measures of transnational ties, social media use, 2020 and 2024 vote choice, and overall opinion of Trump, exposure to, and belief in six stories,[3] four of which were misinformation narratives that circulated within U.S. Latino networks before the 2024 presidential election. I designed the instrument to permit conditional tests of the proposed mechanism.

The results provide support for several predictions of my theory. First, Latinos are more likely than non-Latinos[4] to have transnational ties and to communicate more frequently with people living outside of the U.S. Second, transnational ties are associated with greater exposure to political misinformation. Within-respondent models with story fixed effects and respondent-clustered standard errors show that more frequent contact with transnational ties is associated with a higher probability of having heard the misinformation stories presented in the survey. These effects remain significant after controlling for partisan and demographic variables. Third, the relationship between ties and belief in misinformation is conditional on levels of social media use. In models that include the interaction, the coefficient on ties and social media use is positive and substantial ($\beta = 0.420$, $p < 0.01$). At low levels of

[2]The sampling frames are politically representative "modeled frames" of US adults (Hispanic only for the oversample), based upon the American Community Survey (ACS) public use microdata file, public voter file records, the 2020 Current Population Survey (CPS) Voting and Registration supplements, the 2020 National Election Pool (NEP) exit poll, and the 2020 CES surveys, including demographics and 2020 presidential vote. Find more information about the sampling, weighting, and matching procedures in Appendix E.

[3]The specific stories are listed in the methods section.

[4]Throughout the paper, “non-Latinos” refers to white and Black respondents. Other racial and ethnic groups are excluded from the descriptive comparisons because of insufficient sample sizes.

social media use, the association between transnational ties and belief is indistinguishable from zero. At average and high levels of social media use, stronger ties are associated with greater belief in misinformation. Finally, belief in misinformation is positively associated with warmer evaluations of and support for Trump in 2020 and 2024, even after controlling for demographic characteristics and partisanship.

The current paper makes three contributions. Substantively, it provides a coherent account of recent Latino political behavior that complements existing explanations. Theoretically, it advances research on misinformation by separating exposure from belief, arguing that interpersonal networks shape what people encounter while digital environments condition how that information is evaluated. Methodologically, it uses the Latino case as a setting where cross-border ties make these processes observable. While Latinos are a strategic empirical case, the framework I develop likely applies to any diasporic community whose transnational ties intersect with asymmetric misinformation environments. I begin by reviewing existing explanations for Latino support for Trump. While prior work identifies several important factors, it does not account for how exposure to and belief in political information are structured by social networks and digital environments.

Existing Explanations and the Information Environment Gap

Some explanations for the puzzle of Latino support for Trump emphasize ideological sorting, economic voting, religion and evangelical identity, gendered cultural norms, and the declining force of panethnic group appeals. These accounts generally argue that recent Latino support for Trump reflects underlying preferences and predispositions that align with positions increasingly associated with the Republican Party.

One prominent explanation emphasizes ideological and attitudinal predispositions. For example, Fraga, Velez and West (2025) show that recent Latino support for Trump reflects both compositional and attitudinal differences among Latino voters, including differences in ideology and political predispositions. Carlos, Al-Faham and Jones-Correa (2025) similarly find that partisanship is the strongest predictor of Latino support for Trump in 2020. In their analyses, Latino Trump supporters were more conservative, more likely to hold anti-immigrant attitudes, and more likely to believe the country was headed in the right direction. Further, Latino Trump supporters remained largely unmoved when exposed to information about Trump's restrictive immigration attitudes. These studies suggest that recent Latino voting behavior could reflect a broader alignment between existing ideological predispositions and partisan choice. Emerging panel evidence points in a similar direction. Using panel data from the 2016–2024 American National Election Studies, Villegas et al. (2026) find that changes in support for Trump are associated with attitudes toward issues that the Republican Party increasingly emphasizes, like transgender rights. These findings suggest that at least part of the recent Latino shift reflects changes in partisan alignment. Nonetheless, these changes could also reflect responsiveness to changes in the information environment through which attitudes are formed.

Other scholars have proposed that economic factors explain Trump's support. For instance, Garcia-Rios et al. (2025) find that Latinos who prioritized economic issues were more likely to support Trump over Harris in 2024. Carlos, Al-Faham and Jones-Correa (2025) also find that positive evaluations of the direction in which the country is headed predicted Latino support for Trump. While economic frustrations may have motivated Latinos, we would also expect a similar pattern among other groups affected by the same U.S. economic conditions. However, the increase in support among Latinos was far greater than that of any other group, especially whites and Black Americans, whose support for Trump was mostly stable across presidential elections (Pew Research Center, 2025). Further, the increase from 2016 to 2020 challenges this claim, as would be expected to vote *against* Trump, since he was the incumbent in 2020. Instead, Latinos voted for Trump at even higher rates compared to 2016. Economic dissatisfaction alone does not specify the informational process through which voters assign responsibility or interpret political conditions.

Another set of explanations involves conservative religious values or gender traditionalism, sometimes labeled "machismo culture." Martinez and Martí (2024) find that Latinos' church attendance predicts support for Trump in 2020. While religiosity remains understudied and is likely an important factor, only 17% of Latinos identified as Evangelical in 2024, and a growing number, 30% in 2022, identified as unaffiliated (Nadeem, 2023). Further, the share of Latinos who identify as evangelicals has remained stable over the last decade (Pew Research Center, 2014). While religious identity and church attendance likely contribute to support for Trump among some Latinos, the stability of evangelical identification over time makes it difficult to explain the broader growth in Latino support for Trump solely through changes in religious composition. Additionally, sexism as the reason Latinos increasingly voted for Trump has seen mixed support in the literature. Although not limited to Latinos, Geiger and Reny (2024) show that support for gender and racial status hierarchies is associated with Trump support among non-white voters, including Latino voters. However, other studies have found no link between Latinos' sexism and Trump support (Hickel and Deckman, 2022). Carlos, Al-Faham and Jones-Correa (2025) also find no significant gender differences in Latino support for Trump and no significant effect of beliefs about male leadership.

Another line of research emphasizes group identity, linked fate, and reactions to discrimination. Studies of Latino political behavior have long argued that perceptions of discrimination, anti-Latino rhetoric, and threats directed toward co-ethnics can increase political participation, strengthen Democratic attachments, and mobilize Latinos in defense of group interests (Pantoja, Ramirez and Segura, 2001; Pantoja and Segura, 2003; Barreto, 2010; Sanchez and Masuoka, 2010; Zepeda-Millán, 2017; Gutierrez et al., 2019). Related work on linked fate and group consciousness suggests that many Latinos view their individual well-being as tied to that of the broader Latino community, leading them to respond politically to perceived attacks on co-ethnics (Sanchez, 2006; Sanchez and Vargas, 2016; Sanchez, Masuoka and Abrams, 2019).

Yet recent scholarship has increasingly questioned whether panethnic solidarity uniformly shapes Latino political behavior. Alamillo (2019) finds that Latinos who view racism as a less important political concern were more likely to support Trump, while Hickel et al. (2020) show that co-ethnic identities do not always take precedence over other political commitments. Recent work also points to status distinctions within Latino communities themselves. Uribe (2025) argues that Latinos differ in how they perceive their position within intra-group status hierarchies and that these perceptions can shape preferences for immigration policy, redistribution, and other political outcomes. Similarly, Marsh and Ramírez (2019) argue that the political consequences of group identity vary across contexts, and Hopkins, Kaiser and Pérez (2023) find remarkable stability in Latino partisan identities despite exposure to discrimination and threat. These works suggest that while group-based appeals and experiences of discrimination remain important, they are often filtered through broader political predispositions and partisan attachments.

Existing explanations identify important values, preferences, and characteristics associated with Latino support for Trump. However, they devote less attention to the information environments through which political beliefs are formed and reinforced. While these accounts explain who is more likely to support Trump, they provide less insight into how individuals come to adopt the beliefs and evaluations that underlie those political choices. Transnational ties and social media shape these processes by influencing exposure to and belief in political misinformation.

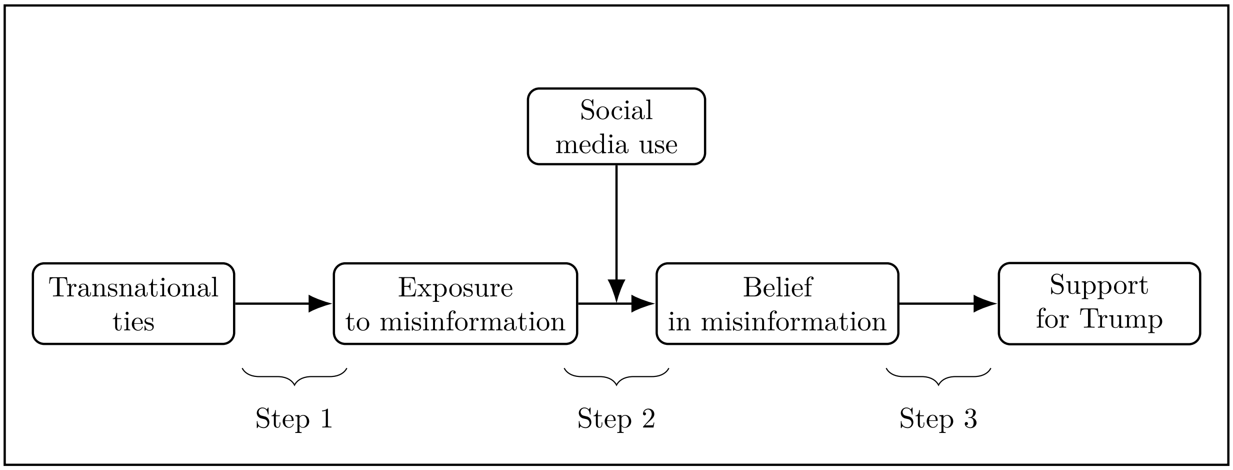
Transnational Information Environments Shape Political Attitudes

Previous research shows that a person's information environment influences their political life (Iyengar and Kinder, 1987; Iyengar, Peters and Kinder, 1982; McCombs and Shaw, 1972). Work in political communication has established that mass-media coverage influences which issues citizens consider important (McCombs and Shaw, 1972), how they evaluate political actors (Iyengar, Peters and Kinder, 1982), and what frames they use to evaluate their vote choice (Iyengar and Kinder, 1987). Subsequent work has expanded on this by exploring other components that matter to a person's information environment. For Latinos, recent work shows that digital and linguistic information environments are especially important: many Latinos access politics through social media, and bilingual or Spanish-dominant users navigate media environments that differ from those of English-dominant Americans (Abrajano et al., 2025). For instance, interpersonal communication can shape the information someone hears, its source, and its perceived credibility (Huckfeldt and Sprague, 1995; Mutz, 2002). Beyond elite messaging, social processes influence the information people encounter, how it is discussed, and how it is validated (Zaller, 1992).

For many Americans, interpersonal networks are often composed of domestic ties, but Latinos have more diverse networks that include both domestic and transnational ties. Americans can find themselves bound by the U.S. media ecosystem and social networks that focus mainly on U.S. politics and news. By contrast, Latinos in the U.S. often maintain ties to communities abroad. These relationships are sustained for a variety of reasons, including family obligations, emotional attachment, continued interest in the fate of the nation of origin, and a desire to maintain cultural identity and a sense of belonging across generations. While these ties may be especially salient for more recent immigrants, they can exist beyond the first generation. Today, those ties can persist as social media platforms have reduced the costs of maintaining these relationships and facilitated the formation and maintenance of communities organized around shared national, ethnic, and Latino identities (Abrajano et al., 2025). Evidence of these robust transnational ties has been documented, for example, through remittances, which remain common even to countries where emigration to the United States has declined over time (Orozco, 2023; World Bank, 2024). Latinos' information environments, then, include information flowing through both domestic and foreign networks, about political content relevant to both contexts. As such, transnational ties may provide an important channel for exposure to political information.

The theory proposes a three-step process linking transnational ties to support for Trump, illustrated in Figure 1. First, transnational ties expand exposure to political information, including misinformation, circulating across borders. Second, social media conditions whether that exposure translates into belief by increasing repetition, reinforcement, and social validation. Third, belief in misinformation is associated with greater support for Trump.

Figure 1. Directed Acyclic Graph for the Theory of How Transnational Ties Relate to Trump Support



Note: The DAG summarizes the full proposed theoretical mechanism. Step 1: transnational ties increase exposure to political information, including misinformation, circulating across borders. Step 2: social media conditions whether exposure translates into belief by increasing repetition, reinforcement, and social validation. Step 3: belief in misinformation is associated with greater support for Trump. Because belief was measured only among respondents who reported exposure, the data do not permit a direct test of whether social media moderates the exposure→belief transition itself. The empirical analysis (Table 3) instead tests a related implication: that social media moderates the association between transnational ties and belief among the exposed.

Step One: Transnational Ties Expand Exposure to Political Information

Migration scholarship has established that contemporary migrants do not assimilate into purely domestic information environments. Levitt (2001), in her foundational ethnography of "transnational villagers," documented the durable cultural, social, and political exchanges between U.S. immigrant communities and their countries of origin. Portes, Guarnizo, and Landolt (1999) provided the conceptual framework, defining transnational ties as regular, sustained, and institutionalized cross-border activities. Subsequent work has documented the consequences of these ties for civic engagement, partisan attitudes, and remittance flows, while also debating their scope and persistence (Eckstein and Najam, 2013; Waldinger, 2015; Orozco, 2023). Survey evidence consistently shows that Latinos report high rates of contact with people abroad (DeSipio, 2006; Pew Hispanic Center, 2007; Jones-Correa and McCann, 2016).

The implication of these cross-border exchanges for political communication remains underexplored. If transnational ties are real and significant, they may play an important role in Latinos' information environment and deserve further attention. I propose that these ties matter because they transmit more than casual apolitical information. Instead, these ties convey political narratives and attitudes, often framed by the lived experience of those living abroad. For instance, someone's relative in Caracas describing the collapse of public services under the Maduro government carries a different kind of authority than an English-language news report, particularly when the relative's account is repeated, embellished, or extended through social media. A friend in Tijuana who describes the violence of the cartels carries a similar authority for U.S. immigration debates. These accounts are produced by trusted contacts whose physical presence is itself the central credibility cue.

Transnational ties function as conduits of exposure. Some of the content traveling through these ties is accurate, some is not. The key is that these ties expose individuals to narratives originating outside the United States that are less prominent in domestic U.S. media. Conversations with relatives or friends abroad may include firsthand accounts of issues such as economic collapse, authoritarian governments, migration, organized crime, or political instability. They provide a context through which later political claims are interpreted.

Many prominent right-leaning misinformation narratives in the United States invoke precisely these themes: socialism, immigration, crime, election integrity. Because transnational ties increase familiarity with these issues through personal relationships, they may make politically lopsided misinformation that coincides with those experiences more salient or more likely to be encountered. I therefore expect respondents with stronger transnational ties to report greater exposure to political misinformation, even after controlling for partisanship and demographic characteristics. Given this, I propose that:

H1: Transnational ties are positively associated with exposure to political misin-

formation.

Exposure vs. Belief: Two Distinct Processes

Exposure does not necessarily translate into belief. Recent research on misinformation shows that these two processes, exposure and belief, are conceptually and empirically distinct (Tucker et al., 2018; Guess, Nagler and Tucker, 2019). Among Latinos specifically, Abrajano et al. (2025) show that reliance on Spanish-language social media for news predicts belief in false electoral narratives. People often encounter false information online, but only some accept it as factual. Earlier studies of misinformation used exposure as a proxy for influence, but subsequent research has highlighted the important distinction between these phenomena. For instance, Guess et al. (2019) concluded that the population that retained or believed misinformation was significantly smaller than that who encountered misinformation. Allcott and Gentzkow (2017) also found that even with high exposure, the downstream effects on vote intention were modest, suggesting a model of the world in which simple exposure does not directly translate into electoral outcomes. Tucker et al. (2018) further clarified the distinction by arguing that identical messages can produce different effects in different people, through different channels of influence. Collectively, this literature demonstrates that exposure alone is insufficient for belief.

Certain characteristics can make misinformation more likely to be believed. A wealth of literature shows that messages are evaluated on more than just their factual content. For instance, people rely on cues such as familiarity with the claim, its source, the emotions it evokes, and whether it feels new or important. Many of these cues can operate simultaneously on social media platforms, a point I return to later in this section. Thus, a message can be more persuasive if it is heard repeatedly, comes from credible sources, evokes emotions, provides novel or salient information, or aligns with prior attitudes and identities (Hovland, Janis and Kelley, 1953; Berlyne, 1960; Zajonc, 1968; Petty and Cacioppo, 1986; Cialdini, 2009; Lodge and Taber, 2013)

Repetition is key because repeated exposure can create a sense of familiarity that may be mistaken for truthfulness. Experimental studies have shown that repetition *alone* increases perceived accuracy and the probability that a false claim is taken as factual, even when the claim is initially implausible or explicitly labeled as false (Fazio et al., 2015; Pennycook, Cannon and Rand, 2018). Given this, simply encountering a message multiple times can make that message appear factual. Social endorsement can reinforce this process in online settings. When a claim is liked or shared by others, it can influence whether a person engages with it, even beyond partisan cues (Messing and Westwood, 2014).

Other characteristics, such as source credibility and social proximity to the sources, also make misinformation more credible. People are more willing to accept a claim when it comes from sources perceived as knowledgeable, trustworthy, or socially familiar (Pornpitakpan, 2004; Messing and Westwood, 2014; Jia et al., 2025). This matters because people residing in Latin American countries can be perceived as knowledgeable and trustworthy sources, given their personal experience with local politics and contexts. A Latino in the U.S. can use the physical presence of their transnational ties as a cue for knowledge and thus be more willing to accept information offered by that tie.

Emotional saliency and novelty also increase the likelihood that a false claim will be accepted. Emotionally charged information is more likely to capture attention, spread through networks, and be remembered, while novel claims can feel informative or urgent (Brady et al., 2017; Vosoughi, Roy and Aral, 2018; Martel, Pennycook and Rand, 2020). Latinos' transnational ties may enable them to share information that is particularly novel or surprising because it comes from contexts outside the U.S. information environment, which can help get the message across more easily.

Motivated reasoning also makes some individuals more likely to accept misinformation that is congenial or congruent with prior beliefs. Skepticism can be lower for claims that align with already held ideas than for those that contradict a person's priors (Kahan et al., 2017;

Strickland, Taber and Lodge, 2011; Flynn, Nyhan and Reifler, 2017). So, misinformation that confirms suspicions can be more easily accepted.

These studies point to several important factors that bridge the gap between exposure and belief. Social media provides an environment where these factors can simultaneously operate, as individuals can repeatedly encounter the same highly endorsed and emotionally charged claim they heard from a credible source, such as a person they know who lives outside the U.S.

Step Two: Social Media Conditions When Exposure Becomes Belief

Social media platforms operationalize many of the factors identified in the misinformation literature. For instance, platform algorithms repeatedly recommend content similar to what users have previously engaged with, thus providing the repetition needed for false claims to appear truer. These can create repeated doses of content across days and weeks (Bakshy, Messing and Adamic, 2015; Bail, 2021). Further, social media platforms provide an important proxy for social endorsement through features such as likes, shares, and comments (Avram et al., 2020). It may be the case that seeing a false claim's popularity online signals credibility or social validation. Encrypted and semi-private messaging platforms compound these dynamics as forwarding obscures a message's origin, and interpersonal sharing increases exposure and trust (Resende et al., 2019; Valenzuela et al., 2019). Lastly, social media plays a key role in the belief of misinformation because it helps to easily spread information that's more emotionally charged. We know from the literature that misinformation is often more emotionally arousing than accurate news, which aids in its "shareability" (Vosoughi, Roy and Aral, 2018; Brady et al., 2017).

For people with transnational ties, social media use matters in specific ways. This expectation builds on evidence that Latinos use social media for political information, and that Spanish-language social media use is associated with belief in political misinformation (Abrajano et al., 2025). Heavy social media use multiplies encounters with content originating in transnational networks; embeds those encounters in feeds that repeat similar content; and surrounds them with social-endorsement signals from co-ethnic peers. A claim about Venezuelan socialism that begins as a single message from a relative becomes, in the heavy social-media user's feed, a recurring piece of content with apparent broad support. For users with low social media use, the same transnational tie produces a single, isolated encounter that is harder to mistake for consensus.

This logic implies that the effect of transnational ties on belief is conditional on social media use. At high levels of use, the digital environment can condition the transnational tie information into a repeated, validated stream of misinformation that results in belief. This conditional logic is an important theoretical claim of the paper and distinguishes the present argument from prior work that has treated transnational ties and digital media as independent influences. Given this, I propose the following:

> *H2: The association between transnational ties and belief in political misinformation becomes more positive as social media use increases.*

Step Three: Belief in Misinformation Is Associated with Greater Support for Trump

The third step in my theory concerns the political consequences of believing misinformation. We know from prior research that when people believe misinformation, factors such as candidate evaluation, vote choice, policy preferences, and trust in institutions can be affected (Allcott and Gentzkow, 2017; Tucker et al., 2018; Hopkins, Sides and Citrin, 2019; Berlinski et al., 2023; Pennycook and Rand, 2021). For instance, some scholars have argued and shown that the 2016 presidential election outcome was influenced in favor of Trump by a Russian-led disinformation effort (Jamieson, 2018). These findings have been affirmed by others who show that exposure to misinformation was associated at least some reduction in support for Clinton in 2016 compared to Obama voters in 2012 (Gunther, Beck and Nisbet, 2019). Further, there may be an asymmetry in misinformation, with pro-Trump false stories more prevalent than pro-Clinton ones (Allcott and Gentzkow, 2017). Notably, what may appear as modest, belief-induced shifts in support for candidates or policies can have larger consequences for the electoral system when these effects are aggregated across constituencies (Allcott and Gentzkow, 2017). Because the supply of misinformation tilts right (Allcott and Gentzkow, 2017; Freelon, Marwick and Kreiss, 2020; Garrett and Bond, 2021), belief in misinformation should pull believers to the right as well. For a respondent who has come to believe that the Democratic Party is pushing socialism, that immigrants are responsible for rising crime, or that the 2020 election was stolen, support for Trump is the politically congruent response. Given this, I propose my last hypothesis:

> *H3: Belief in political misinformation is positively associated with support for Donald Trump.*

Testing the Theory: Latinos as a Strategic Case

While the underlying logic of my theory can apply to other groups, Latinos are a particularly good test case. My theory emphasizes that transnational ties are associated with exposure, that social media use conditions belief, and that Trump support is correlated with belief. Since Latinos are more likely to have ties *and* to use social media to sustain those ties, they present an ideal case for testing my theory. Existing evidence also shows that Latinos are highly politically engaged on social media and that language structures the political information they encounter online (Abrajano et al., 2025). If the proposed mechanism is correct, the case of Latinos should show the correlations I propose. I discuss the generalizability of this case in the discussion section.

The following examples illustrate my theory in more concrete terms. Consider, for instance, two ideal respondents. The first is Ana, who maintains contact with relatives in Venezuela, uses social media daily, and hears from them about state failure under the

Maduro[5] regime. Her relatives share with her that socialism and Maduro are to blame for the current political situation they are experiencing. Ana later goes online and sees a claim on Facebook that the Democratic Party is pushing for socialism in the U.S. Ana does not encounter such a claim out of the blue. Instead, she hears this claim alongside her relatives' stories, which lends it more credence. It seems plausible because it is consistent with what was expressed by her family and friends back home. The second example is Carlos, who does not communicate with people abroad but does use social media. Carlos sees the same claim about the Democratic Party pushing socialism in the U.S. In contrast to Ana, exposure to the claim is unaccompanied by any transnational anchors. This leaves Carlos with fewer cues encouraging him to view the claim as credible. My theory would predict, then, that Ana, but not Carlos, will come to accept the claim, and that will begin pushing her toward Trump. The empirical task is to show that this conditional logic holds for the population from which Ana and Carlos are drawn.

Research Design

Survey Design

I test the proposed theory with an original survey, fielded by YouGov in September 2024, with a Latino oversample. The instrument was administered in Spanish and English. The final sample consists of 1500 respondents: 750 respondents identify as Hispanic/Latino, and 750 do not. The respondents are drawn from YouGov's matched panel, weighted to be representative of the U.S. adult population on age, gender, and education. Respondents in the general sample (not the oversample) are also weighted based on race. The general sample was also post-stratified on 2020 presidential vote choice, as well as a four-way stratification of gender, age, race, and education. Then, for the general sample, there was an additional three-way stratification between age, race, and education. Within the Latino oversample, a separate weight was post-stratified on 2020 presidential vote choice, followed by a three-way

[5]Nicolas Maduro was the President of Venezuela until 2026, before he was captured by U.S. authorities.

stratification by gender, age, and education. Further details about the instrument can be found in Appendix A.

The survey includes both a nationally matched sample and a Latino oversample. The nationally matched sample is used descriptively to compare the prevalence of transnational ties across racial and ethnic groups. Because the theory developed in this paper seeks to explain variation in political attitudes within the Latino population, all hypothesis tests are estimated using the Latino sample only. This design allows the descriptive comparisons to motivate the empirical focus while evaluating the proposed mechanism in the population for which the theory is developed.

Measuring Exposure and Belief Using Misinformation Stories

Exposure and belief are measured against four real misinformation narratives that circulated within Latino digital networks before the 2024 presidential election. The four narratives were chosen from a site[6] that tracks and verifies the veracity of Spanish stories shared online. Two more stories were shown to respondents as robustness checks: one factual story chosen from popular news circulating around the same time, and one false story that was not shared online and was fully fabricated by the author of this paper. The stories are:

Table 1. Specific Stories Shown to Respondents

Story	**Veracity**
Chinese loans and investments are better for Latin American countries than United States loans and investments	False
Biden and Congress are working on banning the Bible	False
Vice President Harris congratulated President Maduro for winning the 2024 presidential election in Venezuela	False
Venezuelan refugees are causing a rise in crime rates in Latin America	False
Some states now allow teachers to be armed in the classroom	True
Phil McClaren secretly owns all social media platforms	Fabricated by author

Note: The first four stories are misinformation narratives. The fifth story is true. The final story is a placebo item fabricated by the author and was not known to have circulated online prior to the survey.

[6] The site is `https://factchequeado.com`

Respondents were shown each story and asked whether they had heard it. If a respondent said they had heard the story, a follow-up question asked them to assess the claim's veracity. Respondents could choose from a five-item scale ranging from "definitely false" to "definitely true". Separating these questions permits independent examination of exposure (heard the story) vs. belief (evaluated the story as true). All respondents were debriefed at the end of the survey, and were shown which of the stories were false vs. true.

Key Independent Variables

The survey asked respondents demographic and partisanship questions in addition to questions about transnational ties and social media use. The transnational ties variable consisted of two questions. First, respondents are asked, "*Thinking about the people you know, do any of them live outside the U.S.*?" If the respondent selected yes, a follow-up inquired about contact frequency, presenting respondents with a set of options ranging from I do not talk to friends and family who live in other countries to I talk to friends and family who live in other countries more than once a week. In addition to questions about transnational ties, the survey also asked about social media use. Respondents were presented with a multiple-choice list of social media platforms. Follow-up questions asked whether they used the selected platforms daily, weekly, monthly, less than once a month, or not at all.

Political Outcomes

The survey asked respondents about their prospective 2024 vote choice, their recall of their 2020 vote, and their overall opinions of Trump.[7] The prospective vote-choice question included a follow-up asking how confident the respondent was in their choice. Respondents who did not vote in 2020 were asked how they would have voted if they did vote. The question asking respondents for their opinion of the candidates presented a list of options ranging from "extremely bad" to "extremely good" to "no opinion." The order of the candidates was

[7] The survey also measured evaluations of Biden, Harris, and Vance. Those outcomes fall outside the scope of the current paper

randomized to diminish response order effects.

Data Preparation and Variable Construction

All variables are rescaled to range from 0 to 1 to facilitate comparability of coefficients across models. Transnational ties are operationalized as a composite measure that incorporates both the presence of ties and the frequency of contact with individuals outside the United States. Respondents with no ties are coded as zero, and higher values indicate more frequent interaction among those with ties. Social media use is constructed as an index that averages self-reported frequency across multiple platforms.[8]

Exposure to misinformation is measured using binary indicators for whether respondents report having heard each of several stories. These items are combined into an index of exposure to misinformation and are also analyzed separately to assess content-specific effects. I report specific story effects in Appendix C. Belief in misinformation is measured only among respondents who report prior exposure to a given story. For these respondents, belief is captured using both a continuous measure of perceived truthfulness and a binary indicator that distinguishes between those who consider the story likely true and those who do not.

All models include standard demographic and political controls, including gender, education, age, income, political interest, and partisanship. Analyses use survey weights to ensure representativeness of the target population.

Analytical Strategy

The empirical approach follows the theoretical structure outlined above. First, I examine exposure (H1), second, belief (H2), and third, downstream political attitudes (H3). Each stage corresponds to a distinct outcome and is estimated using models appropriate to the data's structure.

Exposure (H1) *"Transnational ties are positively associated with exposure to political*

[8] See the list of social media platforms in Appendix A

misinformation."

To assess whether transnational ties are associated with greater exposure to misinformation, I estimate models in which exposure is the dependent variable and transnational ties are the primary independent variable. Exposure is analyzed both as an index and at the level of individual stories using logistic regression models. To evaluate whether the observed relationships reflect network-based exposure rather than partisan sorting, I estimate models within partisan subgroups and include controls for partisanship (as reported in the Appendix). I also estimate pooled models that combine multiple misinformation items and include story fixed effects, thereby increasing statistical power and enabling a more general assessment of the association between transnational ties and exposure.

Belief (H2) *"The association between transnational ties and belief in political misinformation becomes more positive as social media use increases"*

The second stage examines whether social media use conditions the relationship between transnational ties and belief in misinformation. Because belief is only observed among respondents who report encountering a story, these models are estimated on the subset of respondents with prior exposure. I estimate both story-specific and pooled models in which belief is regressed on transnational ties, social media use, and their interaction. The interaction term evaluates whether the association between transnational ties and belief varies across levels of social media use. Pooled models include story fixed effects to account for differences in baseline credibility across narratives and cluster standard errors at the respondent level to account for repeated observations.

Downstream Consequences (H3) *"Belief in political misinformation is positively associated with support for Donald Trump"*

Finally, I examine whether belief in misinformation is associated with attitudes toward Donald Trump. I estimate models in which Trump favorability is regressed on belief in misinformation, controlling for demographic characteristics, political interest, partisanship, and other relevant covariates.

Linking the Steps: Conditional Indirect Relationships

To connect these steps, I estimate models that assess whether the association between transnational ties and Trump support operates indirectly through belief in misinformation, and whether the magnitude of this indirect association varies across levels of social media use. This approach is motivated by the theoretical expectation that the relationship linking transnational ties, belief, and political attitudes is conditional rather than uniform across individuals.

The theory implies a sequential pattern in which transnational ties are associated with exposure to political narratives, while social media environments shape how those narratives are evaluated. A standard mediation framework summarizes this process as a single average indirect association across respondents. By contrast, the present approach allows the magnitude of the indirect association to vary with social media use, providing a more precise test of whether the observed relationships are concentrated among individuals embedded in information environments characterized by higher levels of social media use. Because the data are observational, these estimates are interpreted as descriptive patterns consistent with the proposed theoretical framework rather than as definitive evidence of causal mediation.

Results

I begin with descriptive comparisons showing that Latinos are more likely than non-Latinos[9] to report transnational ties and more frequent communication with contacts abroad. These comparisons establish why Latinos provide an especially relevant case for evaluating the proposed theory. The hypothesis tests that follow are conducted using the Latino sample only, consistent with the paper's focus on explaining variation in political attitudes within the Latino population.

[9]Throughout the paper, "non-Latinos" refers to white and Black respondents. Other racial and ethnic groups are excluded from the descriptive comparisons because of insufficient sample sizes.

I evaluate each theoretical step separately before estimating a moderated mediation model that brings the proposed mechanism together. At each stage, I assess robustness by introducing controls for national-origin group and religious affiliation. The corresponding models are reported in the Appendix, while the substantive findings are discussed alongside the main results. Overall, the evidence is strongest for the first and third hypotheses. Transnational ties are consistently associated with greater exposure to misinformation, and belief in misinformation is consistently associated with greater support for Trump. The evidence for the second hypothesis proposing that social media conditions the relationship between transnational ties and belief in misinformation is statistically significant in the primary specifications but becomes sensitive to additional controls. Accordingly, this portion of the proposed mechanism should be interpreted as suggestive rather than conclusive.

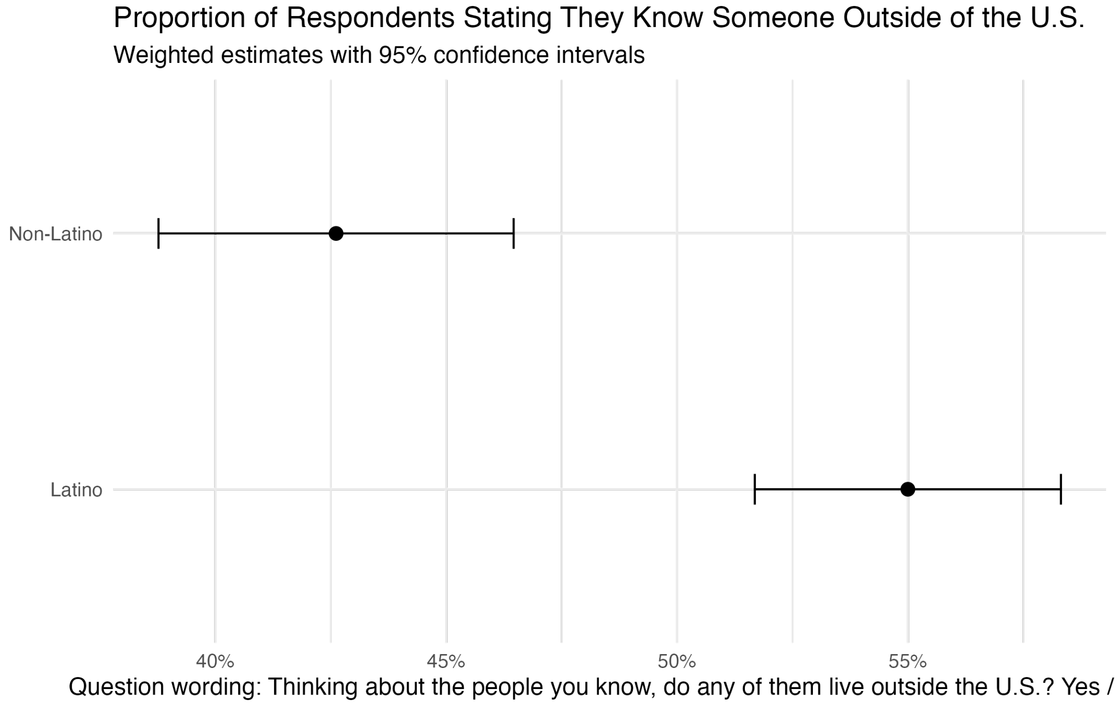
Latinos Are More Embedded in Transnational Information Environments

Before evaluating the hypotheses, I compare Latinos with white and Black respondents to establish whether Latinos are more likely to be embedded in transnational information environments. Because the theory developed in this paper centers on transnational ties, these descriptive comparisons motivate the paper's focus on the Latino sample in the analyses that follow.

Figure 2 shows that Latinos are substantially more likely than non-Latinos to report knowing someone who lives outside the United States. Approximately 55% of Latinos report at least one transnational tie, compared to roughly 41% of non-Latinos. The confidence intervals do not overlap, indicating that this difference is statistically significant. These results suggest that Latinos are considerably more likely to be embedded in transnational social networks that may serve as channels for political information.

Figure 3 examines communication frequency among respondents who report at least one transnational tie. Although the distributions overlap considerably, Latinos are more concentrated at the highest levels of contact frequency, indicating that they are somewhat

Figure 2

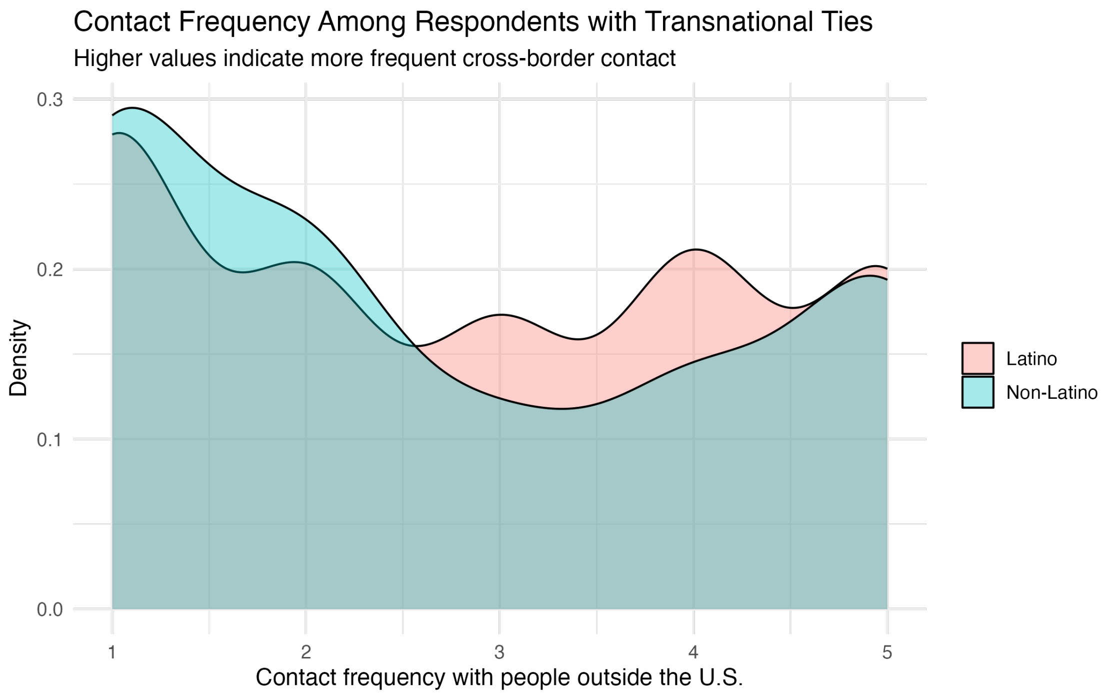


more likely than non-Latinos to maintain frequent communication with people living abroad. Thus, the descriptive evidence suggests that Latinos differ from the comparison groups in two respects: they are more likely to have transnational ties, and, conditional on having those ties, they communicate with them somewhat more frequently. Together, these patterns are consistent with the argument that Latinos are more deeply embedded in transnational information environments, making them an especially appropriate population in which to evaluate the proposed theoretical mechanism.

The theory further proposes that social media helps sustain many of these cross-border relationships. Although the descriptive evidence cannot establish this relationship directly, Latinos also report significantly greater social media use than non-Latino respondents.

Figure 4 shows that Latino respondents report significantly higher levels of social media use than non-Latino respondents. Latinos average approximately .43 on the social media index compared to .36 among non-Latinos, on a scale ranging from 0 to 1, where respondents who use all reported social media platforms daily score 1 and respondents

Figure 3

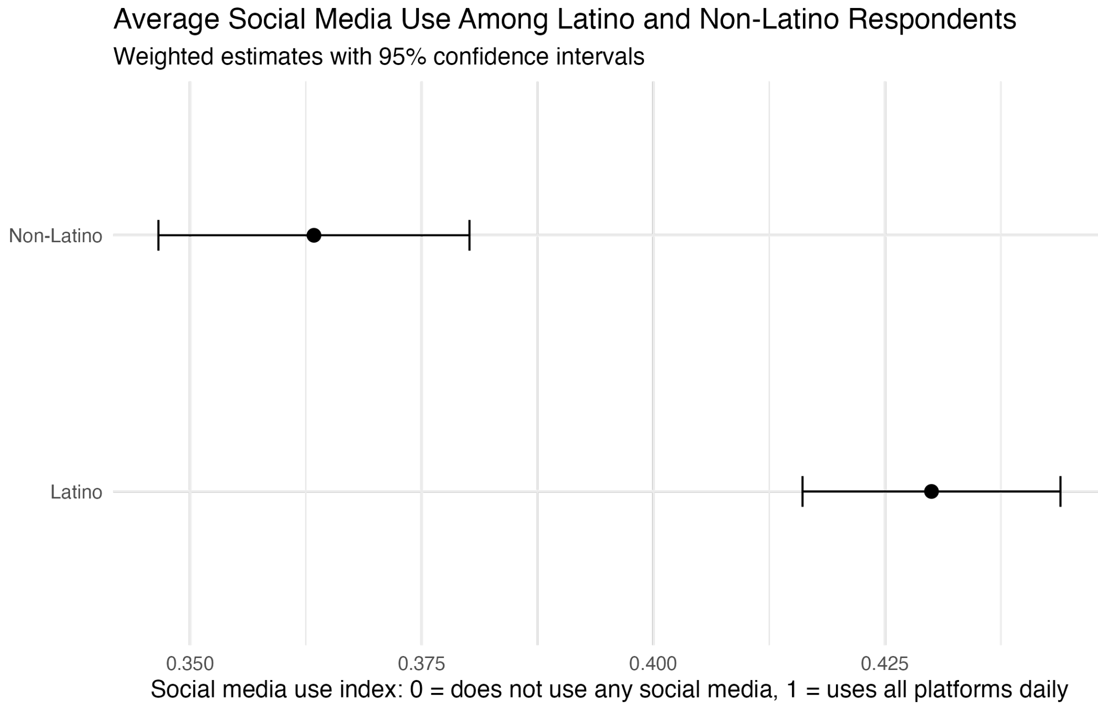


who never use social media score 0. Because the confidence intervals do not overlap, this difference is statistically significant. This pattern indicates that Latinos are more embedded in social media environments. The descriptive evidence is therefore consistent with the paper's theoretical claim that social media serves as an important mechanism through which transnational ties shape political information environments. It is also consistent with recent evidence that Latinos rely heavily on social media for political information and that Latino political activity online is comparable to, and in some contexts exceeds, that of non-Hispanic whites (Abrajano et al., 2025).

Transnational Ties Are Widespread Across the Latino Population

The previous figures showed that Latinos are more likely than non-Latinos to report transnational ties and higher levels of social media use. The following figures examine whether respondents with transnational ties differ systematically from those without such ties within each population. This comparison helps assess whether transnational ties simply proxy

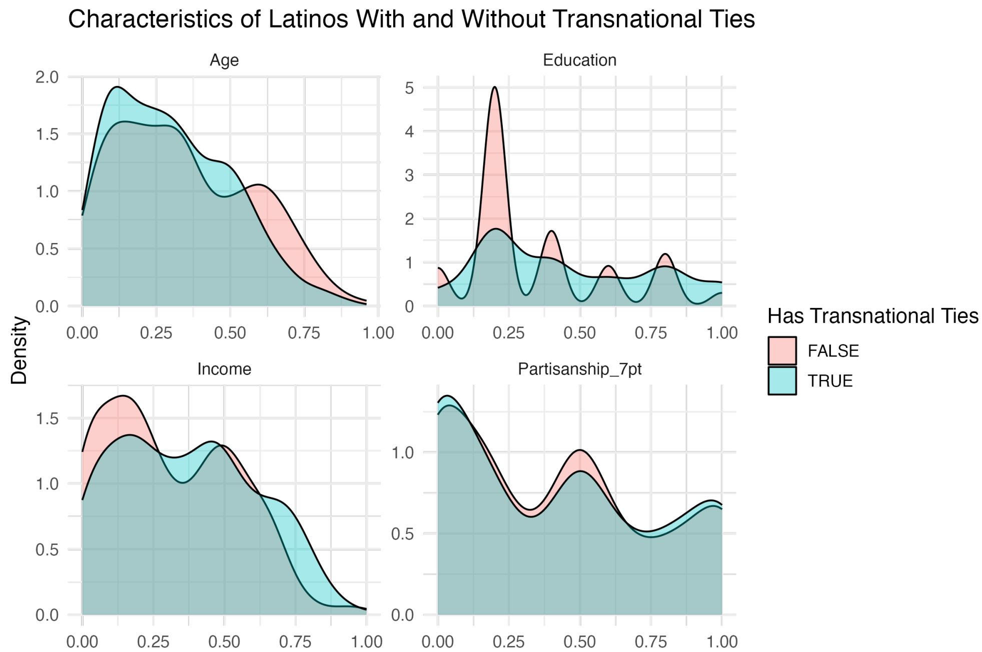
Figure 4



for other demographic characteristics or instead represent a distinct feature of respondents' information environments.

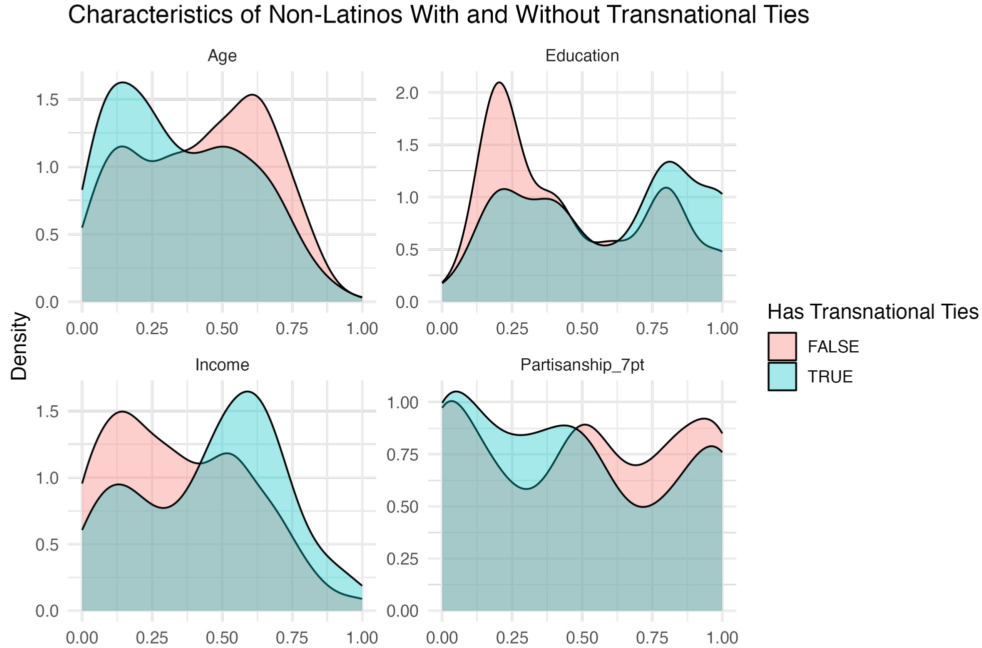
Figure 5 compares Latinos with and without transnational ties. The distributions of age, education, income, and partisanship are remarkably similar across the two groups. Respondents with transnational ties are not systematically younger, wealthier, more educated, or more partisan than those without such ties. Instead, transnational ties appear broadly distributed throughout the Latino population rather than concentrated within a particular demographic or political subgroup. This pattern suggests that, among Latinos, transnational ties capture a meaningful feature of individuals' information environments rather than simply reflecting observable socioeconomic characteristics.

Figure 5



By contrast, Figure 6 shows a different pattern for non-Latino respondents. Among whites and Black Americans, respondents with transnational ties tend to be younger, more highly educated, and have higher incomes than those without such ties, while differences in partisanship remain comparatively small. In other words, transnational ties appear considerably more selective among non-Latinos than among Latinos.

Figure 6



Because transnational ties are not concentrated among a narrow demographic subgroup of Latinos, they are less likely to serve merely as a proxy for socioeconomic status or life differences within the Latino sample. Given this, Latinos provide an appropriate setting for evaluating the proposed theoretical mechanism. Next, I turn to the hypotheses tests. The empirical analyses mirror the theoretical sequence introduced earlier. I first examine whether transnational ties are associated with greater exposure to misinformation (H1), then whether social media conditions the relationship between transnational ties and belief (H2), and finally whether belief in misinformation is associated with support for Trump (H3).

Hypothesis 1: Transnational Ties Are Associated with Greater Exposure to Misinformation

In Hypothesis 1, I proposed that *"transnational ties are positively associated with exposure to political misinformation."* If this expectation is correct, respondents with stronger transnational ties should be more likely to report having encountered misinformation. To evaluate this relationship, I estimate linear probability models using pooled respondent-story data.

The dependent variable equals 1 if a respondent reports having heard a given misinformation story and 0 otherwise. Because each respondent evaluates four misinformation stories, the data are structured in long format, with observations at the respondent-story level. The models include story fixed effects to account for differences in the prevalence of individual narratives, and standard errors are clustered at the respondent level to account for repeated observations. The key independent variable is transnational ties, a continuous measure capturing both the presence of cross-border ties and the frequency of communication with those ties.

Table 2. Hypothesis 1: Transnational Ties and Exposure to Misinformation

	Model 1	
	Coefficient	SE
Transnational ties	0.170***	(0.047)
Generation	0.028	(0.038)
Gender	0.030	(0.037)
Education	−0.008	(0.058)
Age	−0.284***	(0.079)
Political interest	−0.148***	(0.051)
Income	0.073	(0.091)
Partisanship	0.017	(0.047)
Story fixed effects	Yes	
Observations	2,844	
R^2	0.133	
Within R^2	0.077	

Note: Entries are coefficients from a linear probability model estimated using the Latino sample only. The dependent variable is whether respondents reported having heard each misinformation story. The data are organized in respondent–story format, with each respondent contributing one observation for each misinformation story. Story fixed effects account for differences in baseline exposure across misinformation stories. All models control for generation, gender, education, age, political interest, income, and partisanship. Standard errors are clustered by respondent and reported in parentheses. Significance levels: $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

The results support Hypothesis 1. Transnational ties are positively and significantly associated with exposure to political misinformation. A one-unit increase in the Transnational Ties index is associated with a 0.170 increase in the probability of reporting exposure to one of the misinformation stories presented in the survey ($p < .001$). In other words, moving from having no transnational ties to having the highest level of cross-border contact is associated with approximately a 17 percentage-point increase in the probability of reporting exposure to the misinformation stories. This relationship remains after accounting for demographic characteristics and partisanship, indicating that respondents with stronger transnational ties are more likely to encounter political misinformation regardless of their political predispositions.

Among the control variables, younger respondents are significantly more likely to report exposure to misinformation, while gender, education, income, and partisanship exhibit comparatively weak or statistically insignificant associations. Most importantly, the estimated relationship between transnational ties and exposure remains both substantively large and statistically significant after accounting for these potential confounders.

I further evaluate the robustness of this finding by introducing controls for respondents' national-origin group and religious affiliation (Appendix Tables C.1). These are important alternative explanations because both characteristics could plausibly influence the maintenance of transnational ties while also shaping exposure to political information. If the observed relationship were driven primarily by either factor, the estimated effect of transnational ties would be expected to diminish substantially. Instead, the coefficient on transnational ties remains positive, sizable, and significant across these alternative specifications. The persistence of the transnational-ties coefficient across specifications suggests that the observed relationship is unlikely to be explained solely by national origin or religiosity.

The results suggest that transnational ties themselves constitute an important channel through which political information, including misinformation, travels across borders. This first analysis tells us that among Latinos, individuals with stronger transnational ties are systematically more likely to report exposure to political misinformation, consistent with the proposed information-environment mechanism.

Hypothesis 2: Social Media Conditions the Relationship Between Transnational Ties and Belief

In Hypothesis 2, I proposed that *"the association between transnational ties and belief in political misinformation becomes more positive as social media use increases."* This expectation implies that transnational ties expose individuals to political narratives circulating beyond traditional U.S. information environments, while social media reinforces and amplifies those narratives. Consequently, stronger transnational ties should be associated with greater belief in misinformation among respondents who use social media more frequently.

To evaluate this hypothesis, I estimate linear regression models in which the dependent variable is an index of belief in misinformation ranging from 0 to 1. The models include measures of transnational ties, social media use, and an interaction between the two. The interaction allows the association between transnational ties and belief to vary across levels of social media use. A positive interaction coefficient therefore indicates that the relationship between transnational ties and belief becomes more positive as social media use increases.

Table 3 provides initial support for Hypothesis 2. The interaction between transnational ties and social media use is positive (0.420) and statistically significant ($p < .01$), indicating that the relationship between transnational ties and belief in misinformation becomes increasingly positive as social media use increases.[10] Substantively, respondents with stronger transnational ties are more likely to believe misinformation when they are also frequent social media users, consistent with the proposed theoretical mechanism.

The constituent terms of the interaction are also informative. Social media use is positively associated with belief in misinformation ($\beta = 0.186$, $p < .01$), suggesting that greater use of social media corresponds to higher levels of misinformation belief. In contrast, the coefficient on transnational ties is negative ($\beta = -0.112$, $p < .05$). Because this coefficient

[10] Because belief is observed only among respondents who reported exposure to at least one story, this model tests whether social media moderates the association between transnational ties and belief within the exposed subsample. This is the empirically testable counterpart to Step 2 of the theoretical model (see note to Figure 1)

Table 3. Hypothesis 2: Social Media Conditions Belief in Misinformation

	Model 1	
	Coefficient	SE
Transnational ties	-0.112^{**}	(0.051)
Social media use	0.186^{***}	(0.050)
Transnational ties × Social media use	0.420^{***}	(0.096)
Generation	0.033	(0.022)
Gender	0.019	(0.015)
Education	−0.040	(0.027)
Age	-0.078^{**}	(0.038)
Political interest	-0.076^{***}	(0.023)
Income	0.033	(0.032)
Partisanship	0.056^{***}	(0.020)
Constant	0.064^{*}	(0.037)
Observations	711	
Log likelihood	266.808	

Note: Entries are coefficients from a weighted linear regression estimated using the Latino sample only. The dependent variable is an index of belief in misinformation ranging from 0 to 1, with higher values indicating greater belief that the misinformation stories are true. Belief is observed only among respondents who reported having heard at least one misinformation story. The interaction between transnational ties and social media use captures whether the association between transnational ties and belief in misinformation varies across levels of social media use. All models control for generation, gender, education, age, political interest, income, and partisanship. Standard errors are reported in parentheses. Significance levels: $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

represents the relationship between transnational ties and belief when social media use equals zero, it indicates that transnational ties alone are not associated with greater belief in misinformation. This pattern reinforces the theoretical distinction between exposure and belief: interpersonal networks may introduce information, but digital environments appear to shape whether that information is accepted. If anything, respondents who report no social media use exhibit slightly lower levels of misinformation belief as transnational ties increase. Although this negative coefficient was not predicted by the theory, it is consistent with the broader argument that transnational ties, by themselves, are insufficient to increase belief. Rather, the evidence suggests that social media provides the reinforcing environment through which information transmitted across transnational networks becomes more likely to be accepted as true.

Among the control variables, political interest is negatively associated with belief in misinformation. Thus, respondents who report lower political interest are more likely to say the presented misinformation stories are definitely true. Republican partisanship is positively associated with belief, which is consistent with expectations given the ideological content of several of the misinformation narratives included in the survey.

I further assess the robustness of these findings by introducing controls for respondents' national-origin group and born-again Christian identification (Appendix Tables C). Under these more demanding specifications, the interaction between transnational ties and social media use remains positive but is no longer statistically significant. Because these models introduce theoretically relevant controls that absorb variation associated with transnational ties, they provide a conservative test of the proposed mechanism. Accordingly, the evidence for Hypothesis 2 should be interpreted as consistent but not definitive. While the primary specification consistently supports the expectation that social media conditions the relationship between transnational ties and belief in misinformation, the robustness checks indicate that the magnitude and precision of this interaction are sensitive to model specification.

Belief in Misinformation Is Associated with Greater Support for Trump

In my third hypothesis, I proposed that *"belief in political misinformation is positively associated with support for Donald Trump."* If my hypothesis is correct, we should see that belief in misinformation is positively associated with support for Trump, even after controlling for other characteristics. To test this, I estimate three weighted linear regression models. In Model 1, the dependent variable is the respondents' evaluation of Trump, scaled from 0 to 1, with 1 indicating the most favorable opinion. In model 2, the outcome is whether the respondent reported having voted for Trump in 2020. In model 3, the outcome is whether the respondent intended to vote for Trump in 2024. The key independent variable is an index of belief in misinformation, which was also scaled 0- 1, with higher values indicating respondents who evaluate the misinformation as *definitely true.* The models include standard demographic and political controls, including generation (coded as 0- 1, with 0 being first generation). The analyses use survey weights. Standard errors are reported in parentheses.

Table 4. Hypothesis 3: Belief in Misinformation and Support for Donald Trump

	Model 1		**Model 2**		**Model 3**	
	Favorability		2020 Vote		2024 Support	
	Coef.	SE	Coef.	SE	Coef.	SE
Believes misinformation	0.350^{***}	(0.053)	0.318^{***}	(0.065)	0.100^{*}	(0.060)
Generation	-0.061^{*}	(0.034)	0.040	(0.041)	0.031	(0.038)
Gender	-0.007	(0.022)	-0.008	(0.027)	0.011	(0.025)
Education	-0.029	(0.041)	0.063	(0.050)	0.045	(0.047)
Age	-0.049	(0.053)	0.152^{**}	(0.065)	0.049	(0.060)
Political interest	0.062^{*}	(0.035)	-0.119^{***}	(0.042)	-0.094^{**}	(0.039)
Income	0.134^{***}	(0.048)	0.005	(0.059)	0.156^{***}	(0.054)
Partisanship	0.759^{***}	(0.031)	0.695^{***}	(0.038)	0.971^{***}	(0.035)
Constant	0.008	(0.043)	-0.120^{**}	(0.053)	-0.130^{***}	(0.049)
Observations	711		711		711	

Note: Entries are coefficients from weighted linear regression models estimated using the Latino sample only. Model 1 estimates Trump favorability on a 0–1 scale, with higher values indicating warmer evaluations of Donald Trump. Model 2 estimates reported 2020 Trump vote, and Model 3 estimates intended 2024 Trump support. The primary independent variable is belief in misinformation, measured as the average perceived truthfulness of the misinformation stories to which respondents reported exposure. All models control for generation, gender, education, age, political interest, income, and partisanship. Standard errors are reported in parentheses. Significance levels: $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

Table 4 reports the association between belief in misinformation and three measures of Trump support among Latino respondents. The results are consistent with Hypothesis 3. Belief in misinformation is positively associated with Trump favorability, reported 2020 Trump vote, and intended 2024 Trump support. The association is largest for Trump favorability: a one-unit increase in belief in misinformation is associated with a 0.350 increase in Trump favorability on the 0–1 scale ($p < 0.01$), one of the largest substantive associations estimated in the paper. Belief is also strongly associated with reported 2020 Trump vote

($\beta = 0.318, p < 0.01$). The association with intended 2024 Trump support is positive but smaller and less precisely estimated ($\beta = 0.100$, $p < 0.10$), although its direction is consistent with the other two outcomes.

Substantively, these estimates indicate that Latinos who evaluate misinformation stories as more truthful are also more likely to report warmer evaluations of Trump and greater electoral support for him. This relationship remains after accounting for generation, gender, education, age, political interest, income, and partisanship. This pattern is notable because the models already control for party identification. Belief in misinformation therefore captures meaningful variation beyond respondents' baseline partisan attachments.

The Appendix reports additional robustness checks that introduce controls for national-origin group and religious affiliation. These checks assess whether the observed relationship reflects the proposed information-environment mechanism or instead captures characteristics correlated with both misinformation belief and Trump support. The coefficient on misinformation belief remains positive in these additional specifications, suggesting that the relationship is not simply a byproduct of national-origin composition or religiosity.

Bringing the Steps Together: Evidence for the Full Information-Environment Mechanism

The results are broadly consistent with the proposed theoretical sequence. Respondents with stronger transnational ties are more likely to encounter misinformation, greater social media use strengthens the association between transnational ties and misinformation belief, and belief in misinformation is associated with greater support for Trump. The remaining question is whether these relationships, when considered jointly, are consistent with the broader mechanism proposed by the theory. To assess this question, I estimate a conditional indirect association model.

The first stage estimates belief in misinformation as a function of transnational ties, social media use, and their interaction, while the second stage estimates Trump support as a function of misinformation belief. The conditional indirect association is then calculated at low, average, and high levels of social media use using the estimated coefficients from these models. Confidence intervals are obtained via simulation based on the estimated variance-covariance matrix. Full model equations are provided in Appendix D. Because the data are observational, these estimates should be interpreted as descriptive rather than causal.

Figure 7

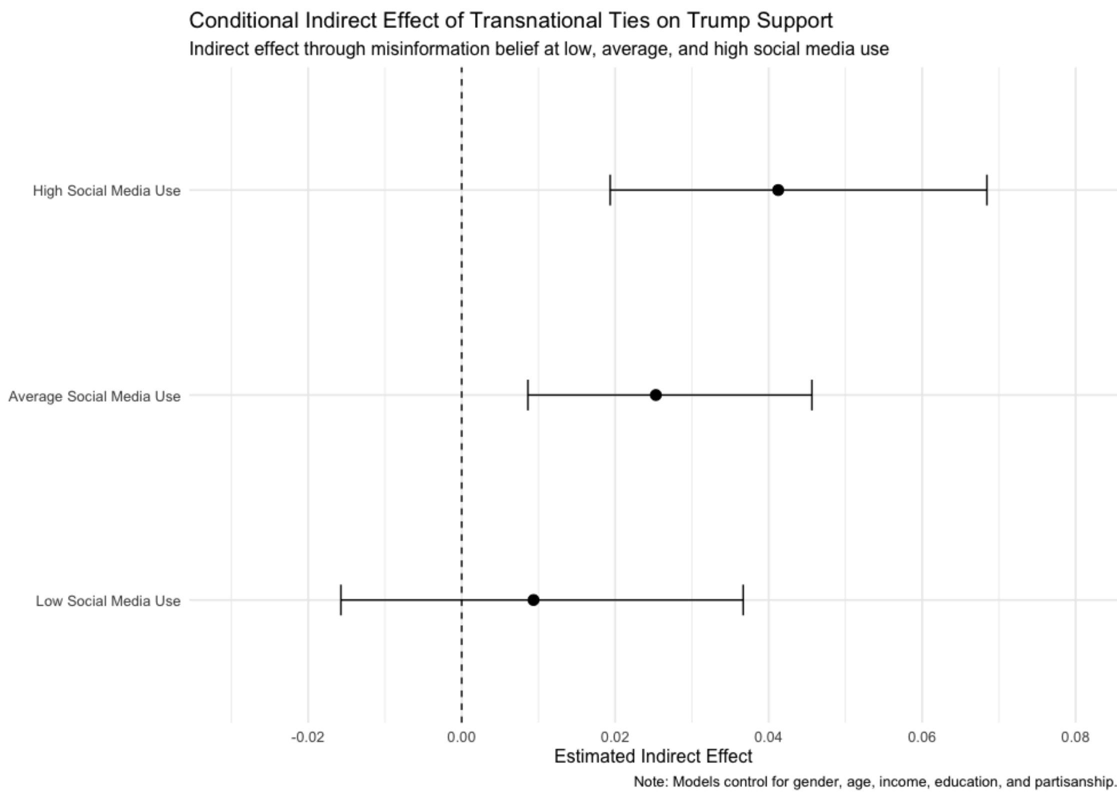


Figure 7 presents the estimated conditional indirect association between transnational ties and Trump support through belief in misinformation at low, average, and high levels of social media use. The conditional indirect associations underlying the figure are reported in Appendix D.2. At low levels of social media use, the indirect association is close to zero and not statistically distinguishable from zero. At average and high levels of social media use, the association becomes positive and statistically distinguishable from zero. This pattern is consistent with the proposed mechanism. Transnational ties are associated with greater exposure to political narratives circulating across borders, while social media environments appear to amplify the extent to which that exposure is associated with belief. Belief in misinformation, in turn, is associated with greater support for Trump. Although the evidence for the moderating role of social media is less robust than the exposure and political-consequence stages, the overall pattern is consistent with the proposed theoretical sequence.

Discussion: Implications of Transnational Information Environments

For the Study of Latino Political Behavior

The findings support an underexamined account that may help explain Latinos' support for Trump in recent elections. Transnational ties expose Latinos to political information that gets amplified for those who use social media more frequently. In turn, those who believe misinformation are more likely to report having voted for Trump in 2020, intending to vote for Trump in 2024, and having a more favorable opinion toward Trump. This pattern is consistent across standard controls.

The proposed theory does not replace or dismiss existing accounts of Latino political behavior. Instead, it adds an explanation centered on the information environment, a feature that existing accounts often understate because they tend to emphasize relatively stable group characteristics, such as ideology, religiosity, or cultural conservatism. The argument is that political attitudes are shaped not only by predispositions but also by the networks through which people encounter and evaluate political information. What was once treated as a linear process of immigrant acculturation and declining ties to countries of origin is now more complicated. Technological change has made it easier and less costly to maintain regular contact with people abroad, while social media has expanded the reach and intensity of political information circulating through those ties. In this context, transnational ties and social media help structure exposure to political narratives, including misinformation.

Latinos are a particularly important case for examining these dynamics because many remain connected to people and information environments outside the United States, while also participating in U.S. political life. This argument complements recent work showing that Latino online political activity is not peripheral to Latino politics but is central to how many Latinos encounter political information, especially across language-specific digital environments (Abrajano et al., 2025).

For the Study of Political Communication

The current work also has implications for the political communication literature. Much of the misinformation literature examines exposure, belief, and political consequences separately. This paper instead treats them as sequential components of a broader information process. By examining exposure, belief, and political consequences as interconnected processes, this paper highlights the importance of conditional relationships within the information environment. The results suggest that the association between exposure and belief may depend on the broader informational context, particularly social media use. Although evidence for this moderating relationship is more sensitive to model specification than the exposure and political consequence stages, the findings are consistent with the argument that information environments shape whether exposure translates into belief. The conditions under which exposure is reinforced, repeated, and validated matter greatly for belief. Additionally, focusing on transnational ties extends the literature by identifying interpersonal networks as a key variable. Prior work has centered on individual-level traits such as knowledge, motivated reasoning, partisan identity, or on message-level features like repetition, emotionality, source, among others. This paper shows that transnational ties are an important element of the information environment, especially for groups like Latinos whose networks extend beyond domestic ones. In doing so, it extends recent work on Latino social media use by identifying transnational ties as a network mechanism that may help explain why certain online information environments become politically consequential.

Beyond the Latino Case

Although I frame this paper around the Latino case, my theory is likely more general. The proposed mechanism may also operate among other diasporic communities that maintain transnational ties and use social media frequently. Latinos, however, are a strategic test given their ties and the content relevant in Latin America, which maps onto the U.S. political landscape. However, other groups, such as Asian diasporic communities, are also embedded in transnational information environments and could provide a valuable extension to the current work.

Alternative Explanations and Limitations

The most plausible alternative explanation to my proposed theory is partisan self-selection. It is possible that people who identify as Republican, or who are already inclined toward Trump, are more likely to have transnational ties, use social media, and believe misinformation. However, the results are not fully consistent with this alternative explanation. The relationship between transnational ties and exposure to misinformation is still positive even after controlling for party identification. Additionally, the relationship between belief in misinformation and Trump support is robust to partisan controls and to changes in the dependent variable, including both favorability toward Trump and vote choice. This suggests that partisanship alone does not account for the relationships observed in the data.

A second concern is whether the observed associations reflect other individual characteristics that are correlated with both transnational ties and political attitudes. National origin is especially important to consider. Cubans and Venezuelans, for example, may be more likely than Mexican-origin Latinos to maintain transnational ties, hold conservative political views shaped by experiences with left-authoritarian governments, and support Trump. Under this explanation, the association between transnational ties and misinformation could reflect the political predispositions of specific national-origin communities rather than the larger information environment process I propose. Religiosity may also matter if more religious

Latinos are both more embedded in community networks and increasingly aligned with Republican social conservatism.

To assess these concerns, I estimate additional models that include national-origin group and born-again Christian identification as controls. The corresponding tables can be found in Appendix C. The robustness checks reinforce the exposure and political consequence stages more consistently than the belief stage. The association between transnational ties and exposure to misinformation is still substantively large and statistically distinguishable from zero after these controls are included. Similarly, the association between belief in misinformation and support for Trump remains substantively unchanged. However, the interaction between transnational ties and social media use in predicting belief in misinformation becomes smaller and is no longer statistically significant. This suggests that the belief stage of the argument is more sensitive to model specification than the exposure and Trump-support stages.

However, the attenuation should be interpreted cautiously. Because belief is only observed among respondents who reported hearing at least one misinformation story, and because the additional controls introduce further missingness, these models are estimated on a more restricted analytic sample. Nonetheless, the robustness checks suggest that the evidence for the moderating role of social media is more suggestive than definitive. The results are consistent with my theory, but they do not conclusively show that social media conditions the relationship between transnational ties and belief independently of national origin and religiosity. More work is needed to understand this relationship.

More broadly, the paper is limited by its reliance on cross-sectional observational data. The theory implies a sequence in which transnational ties increase exposure to misinformation, social media environments shape whether that exposure translates into belief, and belief is associated with support for Trump. However, the data do not allow me to directly observe this sequence over time. The estimates should therefore be interpreted as conditional associations rather than causal effects. Respondents with stronger transnational ties may also systematically differ from those without ties in ways the survey does not capture, for instance, in how recently they migrated, the political media environment of their country of origin, or the ideological composition of their specific transnational networks.

Given these limitations, a conservative interpretation is warranted. The findings supply the strongest evidence for the first and third parts of the argument: transnational ties are associated with greater exposure to misinformation, and belief in misinformation is associated with greater support for Trump. The evidence for the second part of the argument, that social media conditions the relationship between ties and belief, is weaker and more sensitive to additional controls. Subsequent studies should use panel data, behavioral measures of media exposure, and experimental designs to better test the proposed sequence.

Conclusion: Political Information Travels Across Borders

A puzzling pattern motivated this paper: why has support increased among some Latinos despite Trump's anti-immigrant agenda and anti-Latino rhetoric? I argue that part of the answer lies in the information environments in which political attitudes are formed. Many Latinos are embedded in transnational networks that connect them to political discussions occurring beyond the United States. Social media helps sustain those networks and can amplify politically lopsided information that circulates through them. When such claims are repeatedly encountered and come to be viewed as credible, they can become politically consequential.

This paper makes three contributions. First, it offers a new account of Latino political behavior that complements existing explanations centered on ideology, economics, religion, gender, and national origin. Rather than replacing those accounts, it shows that they are incomplete without considering how political information is encountered, transmitted, and evaluated. Second, it advances research on misinformation by distinguishing between exposure and belief. Exposure is structured by interpersonal networks, while belief depends on the larger information environment in which those networks are embedded. Third, it demonstrates the value of studying transnational information environments as a framework for understanding political communication across national boundaries. The Latino case provides a setting in which cross-border interpersonal ties make these processes observable, but the theoretical framework expands beyond Latinos to other diasporic communities whose members navigate multiple national information environments.

More broadly, the findings show that political communication research should pay greater attention to the social and geographic boundaries through which information travels. Political information does not stop at national borders, and neither do the social networks through which it is transmitted. Understanding contemporary political behavior therefore requires understanding not only what information people receive, but also how transnational social networks and social media shape the information environments in which political attitudes are formed.

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A. Survey Instrument and Measurement

A.1. Survey Question Wording

Transnational Ties

- Thinking about the people you know, do any of them live outside the United States?[Presence]
  - No
  - Yes
- How often, if at all, do you talk to friends or family who live in other countries? [Frequency]
  - More than once a week
  - About once a week
  - Every other week
  - About once a month
  - Less than once a month
  - I do not talk to friends or family who live in other countries

Social Media Use

- How often do you use each of the following social media platforms?
  - Facebook
  - YouTube
  - Instagram
  - Snapchat
  - Reddit
  - X (formerly Twitter)
  - Discord
  - Other (please specify)
- Response options:
  - Daily

- Weekly
- Monthly
- Less than once a month
- Do not use this platform

Exposure to Political Information

- Please indicate whether you have heard each of the following stories.
  1. Chinese loans and investments are better for Latin American countries than U.S. loans and investments.
  2. Biden and Congress are working on banning the Bible.
  3. Vice President Harris congratulated President Maduro for winning the 2024 presidential election in Venezuela.
  4. Some states now allow teachers to be armed in the classroom.
  5. Venezuelan refugees are causing a rise in crime rates in Latin America.
  6. Phil McClaren secretly owns all social media platforms.
- Response options:
  - I have heard this story
  - I have not heard this story

- Respondents who reported having heard a story were asked:

  You indicated that you have heard the following story: [Story Text]. To the best of your knowledge, is this story true or false?

  - Definitely true
  - Probably true
  - Could go either way
  - Probably false
  - Definitely false

Vote Choice and Candidate Evaluations

- If the presidential election were held today, who would you support? [Prospective 2024 Vote Choice]
  - Donald J. Trump
  - Kamala Harris
  - I would not vote
  - Other (please specify)
- How confident are you in that choice? [Vote Choice Confidence]
  - Fully confident
  - Mostly confident
  - Somewhat confident
  - Mostly not confident
  - Not confident at all
- Do you recall whether you voted in the 2020 presidential election? If so, for whom did you vote? [Recall of 2020 Presidential Vote]
  - Donald Trump
  - Joe Biden
  - A third-party candidate
  - I did not vote
  - I do not recall

  Respondents who did not vote or could not recall were asked:
- Had you voted in 2020, which candidate would you have supported?
  - Donald Trump
  - Joe Biden
  - Other (please specify)

- Please indicate your overall opinion of each of the following individuals: [Candidate Favorability]
  - Donald Trump
  - Joe Biden
  - Kamala Harris
  - JD Vance
- Response options:
  - Extremely bad
  - Somewhat bad
  - Neither good nor bad
  - Somewhat good
  - Extremely good
  - No opinion

A.2. Variable Construction and Coding

Table 5. Variable Construction and Coding

Variable	**Construction**	**Original Range**	**Final Range**
Transnational Ties	Composite measure combining the presence of ties outside the United States and frequency of contact with those ties. Respondents reporting no ties were coded 0. Higher values indicate more frequent communication with people living abroad.	0–5	0–1
Social Media Use	Average frequency of use across all reported social media platforms. Platform-specific responses were coded from 0 (non-user) to 1 (daily use) and averaged.	0–5	0–1
Misinformation Exposure	Binary indicator coded 1 if the respondent reported having heard a story and 0 otherwise. Exposure was analyzed both at the story level and as an average index across misinformation stories.	0–1	0–1
Misinformation Belief	Respondents who reported hearing a misinformation story were asked whether the story was true or false. Responses were coded from 0 to 1, with higher values indicating greater belief that the story was true. The index averages belief across the four misinformation stories for which the respondent reported exposure. Respondents who did not report hearing any misinformation story are missing on this measure.	1–5	0–1

Variable	Construction	Original Range	Final Range
Trump Favorability	Five-point evaluation of Donald Trump ranging from "Extremely bad" to "Extremely good." Responses were rescaled to range from 0 to 1. Respondents selecting "No opinion" were treated as missing.	1–5	0–1
2020 Trump Vote	Binary variable coded 1 for respondents reporting a vote for Donald Trump in 2020 and 0 otherwise.	0–1	0–1
2024 Trump Support	Binary variable coded 1 for respondents indicating support for Donald Trump in the 2024 election and 0 otherwise.	0–1	0–1
Partisanship	Seven-point party identification measure rescaled to range from 0 (Strong Democrat) to 1 (Strong Republican).	1–7	0–1
Age	Respondent age, rescaled to facilitate coefficient comparability across models.	Varies	0–1
Education	Educational attainment, rescaled to facilitate coefficient comparability across models.	Varies	0–1
Income	Household income, rescaled to facilitate coefficient comparability across models.	Varies	0–1

Table 6. Misinformation Stories

Story	Veracity	Topic	Circulated Online Prior to Survey
Chinese loans and investments are better for Latin American countries than U.S. loans and investments	False	Foreign Policy	Yes
Biden and Congress are working on banning the Bible	False	Religion	Yes
Vice President Harris congratulated President Maduro for winning the 2024 Venezuelan presidential election	False	Venezuela	Yes
Venezuelan refugees are causing a rise in crime rates in Latin America	False	Immigration and Crime	Yes
Some states now allow teachers to be armed in the classroom	True	Education Policy	Yes
Phil McClaren secretly owns all social media platforms	False (fabricated by author)	Placebo Story	No

A.3. Descriptive Statistics

Variable	Mean	SD	Min	Max	N
Transnational ties	0.249	0.344	0	1	1500
Social media use	0.401	0.215	0	1	1500
Belief in misinformation	0.641	0.227	0	1	748
Trump favorability	0.406	0.417	0	1	1468
Heard Chinese loans story	0.175	0.380	0	1	1500
Heard Bible ban story	0.104	0.305	0	1	1500

Variable	Mean	SD	Min	Max	N
Heard Maduro story	0.182	0.386	0	1	1500
Heard Venezuelan refugees story	0.363	0.481	0	1	1500
Partisanship	3.626	2.157	1	7	1442
Political interest	0.666	0.329	0	1	1453
Age	45.037	17.278	18	94	1500
Education	3.252	1.486	1	6	1500
Income	6.396	3.694	1	16	1320

B. Misinformation Stories

Story	**Veracity**	**Topic**	**Circulated Online Prior to Survey**
Chinese loans and investments are better for Latin American countries than U.S. loans and investments	False	Foreign Policy	Yes
Biden and Congress are working on banning the Bible	False	Religion	Yes
Vice President Harris congratulated President Maduro for winning the 2024 Venezuelan presidential election	False	Venezuela	Yes
Venezuelan refugees are causing a rise in crime rates in Latin America	False	Immigration and Crime	Yes
Some states now allow teachers to be armed in the classroom	True	Education Policy	Yes
Phil McClaren secretly owns all social media platforms	False (fabricated by author)	Placebo Story	No

B.1. Exposure and Belief Rates by Story

Story	Heard Story (%)	Mean Belief	Believed Story (%)	N Exposure	N Belief
Chinese loans and investments	17.5	0.586	43.5	1500	262
Biden and Congress banning the Bible	10.4	0.529	42.3	1500	156
Harris congratulated Maduro	18.2	0.639	53.8	1500	273
Venezuelan refugees and crime	36.3	0.700	63.4	1500	544
Teachers armed in classrooms	55.3	0.713	65.1	1500	829
Phil McClaren owns social media	8.7	0.569	43.1	1500	130

Story	Heard Story (%)	Mean Belief	Believed Story (%)	N Exposure	N Belief

Note: Mean belief ranges from 0 to 1, with higher values indicating greater belief that the story is true. Believed Story (%) is the percentage of respondents who rated the story as definitely true or probably true. Belief questions were asked only of respondents who reported hearing the story.

C. Robustness Checks

C.1. Exposure Models with National-Origin and Religion Controls

Table 10: H1 Robustness: Transnational Ties and Exposure to Misinformation, Latinos Only

	Latino		
	Coef.		SE
Transnational ties	0.104	***	0.033
Generation	0.068	**	0.032
Gender	0.048	**	0.021
Education	0.035		0.046
Age	-0.169	***	0.048
Political interest	-0.092	***	0.034
Income	-0.025		0.051
Partisanship	0.013		0.036
Born again	0.108	***	0.028
Cuban	-0.490	***	0.186
Other Latino	-0.366	**	0.153
Num.Obs.	2456		
R2	0.132		
R2 Within	0.075		

* $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$
The smaller analytic sample reflects missingness introduced by the additional national-origin and religious-affiliation controls.

C.2. Exposure Models by Story

Table 11. Story-Specific Exposure Models, Latinos Only

	Chinese loans	Bible ban	Harris–Maduro	Venezuelan refugees	Teachers armed	Phil McClaren
Transnational ties	1.527***	1.030***	0.711**	0.319	0.186	0.402
	(0.294)	(0.387)	(0.305)	(0.253)	(0.248)	(0.408)
Generation	0.203	-0.794*	-0.368	1.378***	-0.214	-0.940**
	(0.339)	(0.456)	(0.352)	(0.277)	(0.263)	(0.474)
Gender	0.846***	0.656**	0.204	0.148	0.332*	0.652**
	(0.231)	(0.305)	(0.231)	(0.180)	(0.173)	(0.309)
Education	0.074	0.295	0.380	0.356	0.256	0.026
	(0.405)	(0.543)	(0.415)	(0.331)	(0.323)	(0.555)
Age	-2.621***	-2.208***	-2.281***	-0.252	1.098***	-3.188***
	(0.587)	(0.766)	(0.590)	(0.423)	(0.411)	(0.833)
Political interest	-0.602	-0.894*	-0.624*	-0.814***	-0.946***	-0.620
	(0.373)	(0.494)	(0.379)	(0.294)	(0.275)	(0.491)
Income	0.508	-2.205***	-0.123	-0.322	0.298	-1.168*
	(0.469)	(0.661)	(0.482)	(0.392)	(0.380)	(0.639)
Partisanship	-0.115	0.287	0.577*	0.361	-0.406*	-0.760*
	(0.303)	(0.393)	(0.307)	(0.245)	(0.237)	(0.423)
Constant	-1.751***	-1.212**	-1.261***	-1.127***	-0.069	-0.619
	(0.430)	(0.553)	(0.433)	(0.348)	(0.333)	(0.559)
Observations	614	614	614	614	614	614

Note: Entries are coefficients from story-specific models estimated using the Latino sample only. Each column estimates whether respondents reported exposure to the corresponding misinformation story. All models use the Latino oversample weight and control for generation, gender, education, age, political interest, income, and partisanship. Standard errors are reported in parentheses. Significance levels: $^{*}p < 0.10$, $^{**}p < 0.05$, $^{***}p < 0.01$.

C.3. Belief Models with National-Origin and Religious Controls

Table 12: H2 Robustness: Belief in Misinformation, Latinos Only

	Latino		
	Coef.		SE
Transnational ties	-0.024		0.052
Social media use	0.208	***	0.051
Transnational ties × Social media use	0.161		0.102
Generation	0.053	**	0.023
Gender	0.030	*	0.015
Education	-0.007		0.028
Age	-0.008		0.039
Political interest	-0.044	*	0.024
Income	-0.030		0.033
Partisanship	0.051	**	0.021
Born again	0.074	***	0.017
Cuban	-0.315		0.194
Other Latino	-0.236	***	0.068
Constant	0.232	***	0.078
Num.Obs.	614		
R2	0.179		
Log.Lik.	100.098		

* $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$
The smaller analytic sample reflects missingness introduced by the additional national-origin and religious-affiliation controls.

C.4. Trump Favorability Models with National-Origin and Religious Controls

Table 13: H3 Robustness: Belief in Misinformation and Trump Support, Latinos Only

	Favorability			2020 Vote			2024 Support		
	Coef.		SE	Coef.		SE	Coef.		SE
Believes misinformation	0.376	***	0.063	0.326	***	0.077	0.120		0.073
Generation	-0.063	*	0.036	0.038		0.044	0.015		0.042
Gender	-0.028		0.024	-0.028		0.030	-0.012		0.028
Education	-0.031		0.045	0.047		0.055	0.035		0.052
Age	-0.051		0.057	0.188	***	0.069	0.039		0.066
Political interest	0.029		0.038	-0.152	***	0.046	-0.104	**	0.044
Income	0.168	***	0.053	0.081		0.064	0.183	***	0.062
Partisanship	0.729	***	0.034	0.611	***	0.041	0.951	***	0.040
Born again	0.078	***	0.027	0.136	***	0.033	0.025		0.032
Cuban	0.037		0.315	-0.158		0.381	0.023		0.365
Other Latino	-0.022		0.110	-0.340	**	0.134	-0.011		0.128
Constant	0.027		0.121	0.193		0.147	-0.096		0.141
Num.Obs.	614			614			614		
R2	0.517			0.364			0.517		
Log.Lik.	-194.321			-301.673			-272.250		

* $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$
The smaller analytic sample reflects missingness introduced by the additional national-origin and religious-affiliation controls.

D. Moderated Mediation Analysis

D.1. Models for the moderated mediation

I estimate two models. First, I estimate the relationships between transnational ties, social media, and belief. This is modeled with the following equation:

$$\text{Belief}_i = \alpha + \beta_1 \text{Ties}_i + \beta_2 \text{SocialMedia}_i + \beta_3 (\text{Ties}_i \times \text{SocialMedia}_i) + \boldsymbol{X}_i \boldsymbol{\gamma} + \varepsilon_i \qquad (1)$$

The interaction term allows the effect of ties on belief to vary with social media. Then, I estimate whether belief predicts Trump support:

$$\text{TrumpSupport}_i = \delta + \theta \text{Belief}_i + \boldsymbol{X}_i \boldsymbol{\lambda} + \nu_i \tag{2}$$

Where:

- X_i = controls (age, gender, education, income, partisanship, etc.)
- $\beta 3$ captures how the association between ties and belief varies with social media

Using estimates from these models, I compute the conditional indirect association between transnational ties and Trump support through belief in misinformation at different levels of social media use. Specifically, the indirect association is calculated as the product of (1) the association between transnational ties and belief, which varies with social media use due to the interaction term, and (2) the association between belief and Trump support. This produces an estimate of how the association between transnational ties and Trump support through belief differs across low, average, and high levels of social media use. Confidence intervals are obtained via simulation based on the estimated variance-covariance matrix of the model coefficients.

D.2. Conditional Indirect Associations

Social Media Level	Conditional Indirect Association	95% CI Lower	95% CI Upper
Low Social Media Use	0.009	-0.016	0.037
Average Social Media Use	0.025	0.009	0.046
High Social Media Use	0.041	0.019	0.068

Note: Entries are conditional indirect associations of transnational ties with Trump favorability through belief in misinformation at low, average, and high levels of social media use. Models are estimated among Latino respondents using the Latino oversample weight. Estimates are descriptive associations, not causal mediation effects. Models control for gender, age, income, education, and partisanship.

E. Sample and Weighting

Appendix G reports additional information about the sample and weighting procedures. The survey was fielded by YouGov from August 29 to September 11, 2024. YouGov interviewed 1,600 respondents, including a main sample of 795 U.S. respondents and an oversample of

805 Hispanic respondents. These cases were matched down separately to two samples of 750 respondents each, producing a final analytic sample of 1,500 respondents. Both samples were matched to sampling frames on gender, age, and education; the main sample was also matched on race. The final dataset includes a combined survey weight, weight_combined, which is used in the main analyses.

E.1. Sample Composition

Sample	Interviewed N	Final Matched N
General sample	795	750
Hispanic Oversample	805	750
Total	1600	1,500

E.2. Weighted vs. Unweighted Sample Characteristics

Characteristic	Unweighted	Weighted
Latino	0.577	0.156
Female	0.532	0.515
Age	45.037	47.676
Education	3.252	3.467
Income	6.396	6.730
Partisanship	3.626	3.845
Political interest	0.666	0.690

E.3. Country of Origin Distribution Among Latinos

Country/Territory	Unweighted N	Weighted Percent
Mexico	333	37.8
United States	178	20.4
Puerto Rico	108	11.4
Spain	73	7.8
Cuba	49	5.2
Colombia	18	2.1
Other	18	2.2
Dominican Republic	16	1.4
El Salvador	16	1.9
Ecuador	13	1.4
Guatemala	13	1.5

Country/Territory	Unweighted N	Weighted Percent
Costa Rica	9	1.2
Honduras	9	1.0
Venezuela	9	0.9
Brazil	8	0.9
Argentina	6	0.9
Chile	6	0.8
Nicaragua	6	0.9
Peru	6	0.7
Panama	3	0.2
Uruguay	2	0.2

Note: Respondents could select more than one country or territory of family origin. Percentages therefore may sum to more than 100.